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HAMMER HANDLE

Abstract

A hammer including a head having a front portion with a striking face that defines a first plane for driving nails. A notch is spaced apart from the striking face and orientated for pulling a nail in a second plane orthogonal to the first plane. A handle extends from the head and includes a first surface having a contoured profile, a second surface opposite the first surface and having a substantially planar profile, a first portion proximal to the head, and a second portion spaced apart from the first portion, wherein a thickness of the first portion is different from a thickness of the second portion.

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATION [0001] This application claims the benefit of and priority to U.S. Provisional App. No. 63/562,899, filed on Mar. 8, 2024, and entitled “HAMMER HANDLE,” the entire contents of which is herein incorporated by reference.

BACKGROUND

1. Field

[0002] The present disclosure is related to a hammer handle that has a variable cross-sectional profile and thickness to optimize strength.

2. Related Art

[0003] In the construction industry, workers regularly use hammers for various functions related to building framing, shaping and hanging drywall sheets, and removal of nails, studs, and the like. The removal of nails may require use of the hammer as a fulcrum such that a worker applies force to the handle, and the handle must be strong enough to withstand these forces. At the same time, there is a desire to minimize both the mass and the cost of the handle.

SUMMARY

[0004] One aspect of the present disclosure is related to a hammer that includes a head having a front portion with a striking face that defines a first plane for driving nails. The hammer also includes at least one notch spaced apart from the striking face and orientated for pulling a nail in a second plane orthogonal to the first plane. The hammer further includes a handle that extends from the head. The handle includes a first surface that has a contoured profile and a second surface opposite the first surface and that has a substantially planar profile. The handle also has a first end that is proximal to the head and a second end that is spaced apart from the first end. A width of the handle is greater at the first end than it is at the second end.

[0005] According to another aspect of the present disclosure, the contoured profile of the first surface includes a pair of outer ridges and a central ridge and valleys that separate the outer ridges from the central ridge.

[0006] According to yet another aspect of the present disclosure, the outer ridges have approximately the same thickness along substantially an entire length of the handle.

[0007] According to still another aspect of the present disclosure, the central ridge has a varying thickness along a length of the handle.

[0008] According to a further aspect of the present disclosure, the handle has a first portion adjacent the head and a second portion adjacent the second end, and wherein the first portion has a constant width along its length.

[0009] According to yet a further aspect of the present disclosure, the second portion of the handle has a width that continuously decreases length in a direction towards the second end of the handle.

[0010] According to still a further aspect of the present disclosure, a grip surrounds the second portion of the handle.

[0011] According to another aspect of the present disclosure, the second portion of the handle has at least one opening and wherein a material of the grip extends through the at least one opening to interconnect the grip with the second portion of the handle.

[0012] According to yet another aspect of the present disclosure, a pair of claws extend from the head to distal ends. The distal ends of the claws lie in a common third plane with a lower surface of the front portion of the head. The planar second surface of the handle includes a plurality of angle indicia with lines that point directly towards the distal ends of the claws so that the hammer can be rotated about a pivot point established by the distal ends of the claws to a desired angle so that a line at that angle can be established using the handle as a guide.

[0013] According to still another aspect of the present disclosure, the second surface further

includes measurement indicia which indicate distance from the common third plane.

[0014] According to a further aspect of the present disclosure, the handle is made of metal.

[0015] According to yet a further aspect of the present disclosure, the at least one notch is attached to the handle adjacent to the head.

[0016] According to still a further aspect of the present disclosure, the at least one notch is integrally formed as part of the head.

[0017] Another aspect of the present disclosure is related to a hammer that includes a head with a striking face for driving nails in a first plane. The hammer further includes at least one notch that is spaced apart from the striking face and is orientated for pulling a nail in a second plane that is orthogonal to the first plane. A handle extends from the head to a distal end. The handle has a first surface with a contoured profile and an opposing second surface that is substantially planar. The contoured profile of the first surface including a pair of outer ridges and a center ridge that is positioned between the outer ridges. The outer ridges and the center ridge extending along a majority of a length of the handle.

[0018] According to another aspect of the present disclosure, the handle includes a first portion adjacent the head and a second portion adjacent the distal end, and wherein the handle has a reduced width along a full length of the second portion than at any point in the first portion.

[0019] According to yet another aspect of the present disclosure, the outer ridges have constant thicknesses along a length of the handle and the center ridge has a varying thickness along the length of the handle.

[0020] According to still another aspect of the present disclosure, the center ridge has a first thickness adjacent the head and has a second thickness adjacent the distal end and wherein the second thickness is less than the first thickness.

[0021] According to a further aspect of the present disclosure, the head further includes a pair of claws extending from the head to distal ends, the distal ends of the claws lying in a common plane with a lower surface of the front portion of the head. The planar second surface of the handle includes a plurality of angle indicia with lines that point directly towards the distal ends of the claws so that the hammer can be rotated about a pivot point established by the distal ends of the claws to a desired angle so that a line at that angle can be established using the handle as a guide.

[0022] Yet another aspect of the present disclosure is related to a hammer that includes a head with a striking face for driving nails and a pair of claws for pulling nails. The hammer further includes at least one notch spaced between the striking face and the claws for pulling nails in a second plane that is orthogonal to the first plane. A handle extends from the head to a distal end. The handle has a first surface with a contoured profile and an opposing second surface that is substantially planar. The contoured profile of the first surface includes a pair of outer ridges and a center ridge that is positioned between the outer ridges. The outer ridges and the center ridge extending along substantially an entire length of the handle.

[0023] According to another aspect of the present disclosure, the handle has a first width adjacent the head and has a second width that is less than the first width adjacent the distal end.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0024] In the following description, details are set forth to provide an understanding of the present disclosure and are understood not to be limiting. In some instances, certain systems, structures and techniques have not been described or shown in detail in order not to obscure the disclosure. The features previously discussed and other features and advantages of the invention will become more readily appreciated when considered in connection with the following description of the presently preferred exemplary embodiments, appended claims, and accompanying drawings, in which:

[0025] FIG. **1** is a perspective view of a hammer constructed according to a first embodiment of the present invention;

[0026] FIG. **2** is a front perspective view of the hammer in FIG. **1**;

[0027] FIG. **3** is a rear perspective view of the hammer in FIG. **1**;

[0028] FIG. **4** is an elevation view of the hammer in FIG. **1**;

[0029] FIG. **5** is an elevation view of the hammer in FIG. **1**;

[0030] FIG. **6** is an elevation view of a schematic drawing of a hammer constructed according to a second embodiment of the present invention;

[0031] FIG. **7** is an elevation view of a schematic drawing of the hammer in FIG. **6**;

[0032] FIG. **8** is an elevation view of a schematic drawing of the hammer in FIG. **6**;

[0033] FIG. **9** is a cross-sectional perspective of a handle of the hammer in FIG. **6**;

[0034] FIG. **10** is a cross-sectional perspective of a handle of the hammer in FIG. **6**;

[0035] FIG. **11A** is a cross-sectional view of the hammer taken through line **11A-11A** of FIG. **8**;

[0036] FIG. **11B** is a cross-sectional view of the hammer taken through line **11B-11B** of FIG. **8**;

[0037] FIG. **12A** is a cross-sectional view of the hammer taken through line **12A-12A** of FIG. **8**;

[0038] FIG. **12B** is a cross-sectional view of the hammer taken through line **12B-12B** of FIG. **8**;

[0039] FIG. **13** is an elevation view of a hammer constructed according to a third embodiment of the present disclosure;

[0040] FIG. **14** is an elevation view of the hammer in FIG. **13** being used to draw on a surface;

[0041] FIG. **15** is an elevation view of the hammer in FIG. **13** being used to draw on a surface;

[0042] FIG. **16** is an elevation view of the hammer in FIG. **13** from a different perspective;

[0043] FIG. **17** is an elevation view of the hammer in FIG. **13** being used to draw an angle on a surface; and

[0044] FIG. **18** is a bottom view of the hammer in FIG. **1** including a slot for receiving a nut or bolt.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE ENABLING EMBODIMENTS

[0045] Referring to the Figures, wherein like numerals indicate corresponding parts throughout several views, the present disclosure relates to an improved multi-tool device that has the general form of a hammer **20**. As discussed in further detail below, the hammer **20** has a number of built-in features that are functional and allow the hammer **20** to perform other functions beyond pounding and pulling nails. These features are incorporated into the hammer **20** in such a way that the basic shape of the hammer **20** remains intact, and thus, the hammer's **20** ability to drive nails is not compromised. In various embodiments discussed below, some (but not all) of the additional functions that the hammer **20** is able to perform include measuring and drawing angles; measuring lengths; locating studs behind a drywall sheet; tightening fasteners; starting nails; and starting fencing staples. As also discussed in further detail below, a handle **24** of the hammer **20** has a unique cross-sectional shape that provides it with exceptional strength and resistance to deformation in two orthogonal directions, thereby allowing the handle **24** to be made with low mass while still being able to resist impact and bending forces when pulling nails with either claws or a side nail puller.

[0046] Referring to FIGS. **1-5**, a first exemplary embodiment of the hammer **20** is generally shown. The hammer **20** has a head **22** and a handle **24** that extends away from the head **22** in a first direction. The head **22** extends lengthwise in a second direction from a face **26** at one end to a pair of claws **28** at an opposite end. The second direction along which the head **22** extends that is perpendicular to the first direction along which the handle **24** extends. The head **22** has opposing cheeks **30**, which lie in respective planes that are parallel with each other and are perpendicular to a plane of the face **26**. In the exemplary embodiment, the face **26** has a hexagonal shape and is textured. However, in other embodiments, the face may have alternate shapes, textures, and/or configurations. The claws **28** are spaced apart from one another by a converging groove for receiving and pulling nails. The cheeks **30** may be partially concaved relative to the outer surface

of the head **22** to reduce the mass of the head **22**. As with conventional hammers, a user can hold and swing the hammer **20** from the handle **24** to drive nails with the face **26** and can pull nails with the claws **28**. Thus, the hammer **20** satisfies the basic purpose of a conventional hammer.

[0047] The handle **24** can be made of a range of materials, such as wood, a thermosetting polymer matrix (e.g., fiberglass or the like), a metal or metal alloy (e.g., iron, steel, titanium, or the like). The head **22** can also be made of a range of materials, including a metal or metal alloy (e.g., iron, steel, titanium, or the like). The head **22** may be monolithically formed with the handle **24**, such as through casting, forging, and/or machining. Alternatively, the head **22** can be attached to the handle **24**. In some embodiments, the head **22** is joined with the handle **24** by inserting a portion of the handle **24** into a hole within the head **22** and using wedges, welding, an adhesive, or the like to bind the head **22** and handle **24** together.

[0048] In the first exemplary embodiment, the hammer **20** includes a first nail pulling notch **32a** that is located on one side of the head **22**, is integrally formed as part of the head **22**, and is longitudinally offset from the face **26** in the second direction. The hammer **20** of the first exemplary embodiment also includes a second nail pulling notch **32b** that is located on the handle **24** proximal to the head **22** and protrudes outwardly from the handle **24**. The second nail pulling notch **32b** is cube-shaped with a smooth angular recession. In this embodiment, the second nail pulling notch **32b** is integrally formed as part of the handle **24**. The nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b** face in a third direction that is perpendicular to the first and second directions and allow a user to access nails in situations where using the claws **28** would be difficult or impossible. In these situations, the user leverages and stresses the handle **24** in a direction that is orthogonal to the direction in which the handle **24** is stressed when the user swings the hammer **20** to drive a nail with the face **26** or uses the claws **28** to pull a nail. In other words, as shown in FIGS. **4** and **5**, the face **26** defines a first plane **34** in which the user may drive a nail and the nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b** define second planes **36** that are orthogonal to the first plane **34**. Thus, the handle experiences a different bending force, or moment, when either of the nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b** is used as compared to conventional hammer uses, i.e., striking nails with the face or pulling nails with the claws.

[0049] In order to maintain structural integrity when using the nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b**, the handle **24** is shaped to provide it with sufficient strength to resist plastic deformation or fracture when stressed either in a first bending direction during conventional use of the hammer **20** (to strike nails or pull nails with the claws) or in a second bending direction when pulling nails with the nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b**.

[0050] Turning now to FIGS. **6-11**, as viewed in cross-section, the handle **24** has a shape that approximates a C-channel but with the addition of the central ridge **56**. This cross-sectional shape of the handle **24** is symmetrical about a vertical centerline and includes opposing first and second surfaces **48**, **50**. The first surface **48** has a contoured surface to reduce the mass of the handle **24** while maintaining its stiffness in the second bending direction. The second surface **50** is substantially flat or planar. The undulations on the first surface **48** include a first outer ridge **52** at one side of the handle **24** and a second outer ridge **54** opposite to the first ridge **52** and at the other side of the handle **24**. The first surface **48** further includes a central ridge **56** that is located between the first and second ridges **52**, **54**, and recessions **58a**, **58b** are located between the central ridge **56** and the first and second ridges **52**, **54** respectively. The ridges **52**, **54**, **56** and recesses **58a**, **58b** extend substantially the entire length of the handle **24**, i.e., at least 95% of the length **39** between the upper end **44** and the lower end **46**.

[0051] In the exemplary embodiment, both of the first and second ridges **52**, **54** have identical shapes and are rounded along the top and along the sides. Similarly, the top and sides of the central ridge **56** and the bottom and sides of the recessions **58a**, **58b** are rounded with small planar portions in the exemplary embodiment.

[0052] As viewed in cross-section, the handle **24** also has a first side **40** and a second side **42** that

together define a lateral width **38** along a lateral axis or the second direction. The lateral width **38** of the handle **24** decreases from the upper end **44** to the lower end **46**. More specifically, the lateral width **38** at the upper end **44** is greater than the lateral width at the lower end **46**. This decrease in the lateral width **38** also further reduces the cost to produce the handle **24** by requiring less material and reduces the mass of the hammer **20**. The resistance to deformation is not compromised by the decrease in lateral width **38** because the inertia of the handle **24** is greatest at the location of maximum stress or moment in the handle **24**, which is adjacent the end **44** when the nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b** are being used. Beyond cost savings, the reduced mass enhances user comfort, increases efficiency, and improves safety.

[0053] The decrease in the lateral width **38** from the upper end **44** to the lower end **46** can be gradual or substantial. In the exemplary embodiment, the lateral width **38** is constant from the upper end **44** to a grip attachment point **62** that is approximately halfway between the upper and lower ends **44**, **46**. Below the grip attachment point **62** the lateral width **38** is markedly reduced (e.g., a step-change or the like) and then tapers continuously in the first direction from the grip attachment point **62** to a base **64** that is located at the lower end **46**. The marked reduction in the lateral width **38** provides a space for a grip **66** to be attached to the handle **24** such that the grip **66** can be in line with the outer surface of the handle **24**. In the exemplary embodiment, the handle **24** has a constant width of 1.087 inches from the upper end **44** to the grip attachment point **62**. Below the grip attachment point **62**, in the area of the handle **24** that is hidden within the grip **66**, the width tapers continuously to the base **64**.

[0054] The grip **66** can be composed of any suitable material for providing increased friction between a user's hand and the grip and/or for absorbing vibrations transferred to the user's hand (e.g., rubber, an elastomeric polymer, or the like). In the exemplary embodiments, the handle **24** includes slots **68** or openings or through passages for a grip **66** composed of a polymer to flow through and secure the grip **66** to the handle **24** when the polymer cures during a molding operation. In other words, the slots **68** or through holes allow the grip **66** to be molded in place onto the handle **24** in the area between the grip attachment point **62** and the base **64** to thereby establish an extremely strong and durable connection between the grip **66** and the handle **24**. The grip **66** can also include a corrugated surface **70**.

[0055] The handle **24** also has a transverse thickness **60** on a transverse axis that is defined by the distance between the first surface **48** and the second surface **50**. Due to the contoured profile of the first surface **48**, the thickness varies across the handle from one side **40** of the handle to the other side **42**. One benefit of the varying transverse thickness **60** is that less material is required to produce the handle **24** as compared to a traditional rectangular shape without compromising the strength of the handle **24** when the nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b** are being used. In other words, a user can use either of the nail pulling notches **32a**, **32b** and apply force to the handle **24** without risk that the handle **24** will bend or break. The reduced amount of material used in making this shape both reduces the cost to manufacture the handle **24** and also makes the hammer **20** less massive, thereby making it easier to swing and use. The thickness **60** of the handle is maximum in the areas of the first and second ridges **52**, **54**. In other words, the central ridge **56** does not rise as far from the second surface **50** as the first and second ridges **52**, **54** do.

[0056] The dimensions of the first and second ridges **52**, **54**, the central ridge **56**, and the recessions **58a**, **58b** may be different depending on the various portions, segments, or cross-sections of the handle **24** from the upper end **44** to the lower end **46**. For example, changes in the lateral width **38** can affect the width of the first and second ridges **52**, **54**, the central ridge **56**, and/or the recessions **58a**, **58b** such that the contoured profile of the first surface **48** may be more or less rounded, angular, or the like. That is, while the same general shape with the contoured first surface **48** that has the ridges **52**, **54**, **56** and the flat second surface **50** remains the same, the relative dimensions of these features may change along the length of the handle **24**.

[0057] In the exemplary embodiment, the transverse thickness **60** of the handle varies along the

length of the handle **24** in some locations, such as at the central ridge **56**, but is constant at other locations, such as at the first and second ridges **52**, **54**. More specifically, the maximum transverse thickness **60** at the first and second ridges **52**, **54** is approximately 0.335 inches along substantially the entire length of the handle **24** from the upper end **44** to the lower end **46**. However, in the region of the central ridge **56**, the thickness **60** gradually decreases from 0.328 inches at the location of FIG. **8D**, which is adjacent the upper end **44** to 0.195 inches at the location of FIG. **8E**, which is adjacent the lower end **46**. FIGS. **11A**, **11B**, **12A**, and **12B** show specific dimensions of the first and second edges **52**, **54**, the central ridge **56**, and the recessions **58a**, **58b** at various locations along the length of the handle **24**.

[0058] The hammer **20** can also be used to draw lines, measure lengths, and measure angles. With reference to FIGS. **13-17**, to perform this function the head **22** has at least two (three in the third exemplary embodiment) co-planar features. Specifically, in the head **22**, the three co-planar surfaces area include a lower surface **72** of a front area adjacent to the face **26**, a shoulder **74** adjacent to where the head **22** connects to the handle **24**, and the distal ends of the claws **28**. In other words, all three of these features (the lower surface **72**, the shoulder **74**, and the ends of the claws **28**) lie in a common third plane **76**. Optionally, an uppermost surface **78** of the head **22** may extend linearly in a fourth plane **80** that is parallel to the third plane **76**. At least one side surface at the first or second ends **40**, **42** of the handle **24** and extends linearly from the head **22** and perpendicular to the third plane **76** for a certain distance. In the third exemplary embodiment, both the side surfaces of the handle at the first and second ends **40**, **42** are parallel with one another such that both side surfaces extend linearly from the head **22** and perpendicular to the third plane **76**.

[0059] Thus, as shown in FIG. **14**, one method of drawing a perpendicular line involves the user placing all three of the co-planar surfaces (the lower surface **72**, the shoulder **74**, and the ends of the claws **28**) against a measuring surface, such as on a wood board or the like. The user then uses the linear side surface on the handle **24** as a straight edge to draw a line on the wood board with a writing utensil. As shown in FIG. **15**, an alternate method of drawing a perpendicular line involves the user butting the uppermost surface **78** against a top surface and using the linear side surface of the handle **24** as a straight edge to draw a line on the wood board.

[0060] As shown in FIGS. **13-15** the second surface **50** of the handle **24** can include measurement indicia **82**. Accordingly, the hammer **20** can be used as a ruler by placing all three co-planar surfaces against a measuring surface and using the measuring indicia **82** to measure a distance on the measuring surface. The measuring indicia **82** may include measuring units from a variety of measuring systems such as inches, centimeters, or the like, or a combination or sub-combination thereof.

[0061] The hammer **20** can also be used to conveniently and easily measure and draw desired angles other than ninety degree onto objects, such as drywall sheets or wood boards. Referring to FIG. **13**, the second surface **50** of the handle **24** can include angle indicia **84**, in combination with or separate from the measuring indicia **82**. The angle indicia **84** includes a plurality lines that all point directly to the distal ends of the claws **28** and that indicate respective angles from the ends of the claws **28** relative to the third plane **76**.

[0062] The angle indicia **84** may include measuring units from a variety of measuring systems such as degrees, common cuts measured in rise over run ratios that are common in the building construction industry, or the like. Referring to FIG. **16**, in the third exemplary embodiment, the handle **24** is provided with two different sets of angle indicia **84**. One set of angle indicia **84** is measure in units of degrees and the other set is common cut ratios with the run being fixed at **12**. For example, the common cuts angle indicia **84** includes markings that correspond to 1:12 to 14:12 common cuts. As shown in FIG. **17**, to draw an angled line, first the user places the three co-planar surfaces of the head **22** against a measuring surface. Next, the user pivots the hammer **20** about the ends of the claws **28** until the measuring surface is aligned with a desired angle indicia **84**. The user then holds the hammer **20** at this particular orientation and traces along the linear portion of the

handle **24** to draw a straight line onto the measuring surface at the desired angle. An angle can be measured by a similar process.

[0063] As shown in FIG. **18**, the base **64** of the handle **24** includes a slot **86** for receiving a nut or bolt. The slot **86** is disposed on a bottom surface **88** of the base **64**. The slot **86** is recessed into the handle **24** such that it has a depth that is suitable for fully covering the nut. The slot **86** is also shaped to match the shape of the nut such that when the nut is within the slot **86** the handle **24** can be rotated to apply torque to the nut and rotate the nut. In particular, the slot **86** may be shaped to match a 13 mm nut or bolt (e.g., the slot **86** may have a hexagonal shape configured to match the hexagonal shape of a 13 mm nut or bolt). The slot **86** may also include other shapes such as circles, squares, rectangles, other sided polygons, or the like. In some embodiments, the slot **86** is configured to receive a nut for controlling a safety feature of a machine such as a saw mill wherein rotation of the handle **24** causes the nut to rotate and activate or deactivate the safety feature based on the angle of rotation.

[0064] Obviously, many modifications and variations of the present invention are possible in light of the above teachings and may be practiced otherwise than as specifically described while within the scope of the appended claims. These antecedent recitations should be interpreted to cover any combination in which the inventive novelty exercises its utility. Additionally, it is to be understood that all features of all claims and all embodiments can be combined with each other as long as they do not contradict each other. Further, it is to be understood that certain terms of direction, such as upper, lower, top, bottom, side, are in reference to the orientation of the hammer as shown in FIG. **1** and are not intended to be limiting.

Claims

1. A hammer, comprising: a head having a front portion with a striking face that defines a first plane for driving nails; at least one notch spaced apart from the striking face and orientated for pulling a nail in a second plane orthogonal to the first plane; and a handle extending from the head, the handle including: a first surface having a contoured profile, a second surface opposite the first surface and having a substantially planar profile, a first end proximal to the head, a second end spaced apart from the first end, and wherein a width of the handle is greater at the first end than it is at the second end.
2. The hammer as set forth in claim 1, wherein the contoured profile of the first surface includes a pair of outer ridges and a central ridge and valleys that separate the outer ridges from the central ridge.
3. The hammer as set forth in claim 2, wherein the outer ridges have approximately the same thickness along substantially an entire length of the handle.
4. The hammer as set forth in claim 3, wherein the central ridge has a varying thickness along a length of the handle.
5. The hammer as set forth in claim 1, wherein the handle has a first portion adjacent the head and a second portion adjacent the second end, and wherein the first portion has a constant width along its length.
6. The hammer as set forth in claim 5, wherein the second portion of the handle has a width that continuously decreases length in a direction towards the second end of the handle.
7. The hammer as set forth in claim 6, further including a grip that surrounds the second portion of the handle.
8. The hammer as set forth in claim 7, wherein the second portion of the handle has at least one opening and wherein a material of the grip extends through the at least one opening to interconnect the grip with the second portion of the handle.
9. The hammer as set forth in claim 1 further comprising: a pair of claws extending from the head to distal ends, the distal ends of the claws lying in a common third plane with a lower surface of the

front portion of the head; and wherein the planar second surface of the handle includes a plurality of angle indicia with lines that point directly towards the distal ends of the claws so that the hammer can be rotated about a pivot point established by the distal ends of the claws to a desired angle so that a line at that angle can be established using the handle as a guide.

10. The hammer as set forth in claim 9 wherein the second surface further includes measurement indicia which indicate distance from the common third plane.

11. The hammer as set forth in claim 1 wherein the handle is made of metal.

12. The hammer as set forth in claim 1 wherein the at least one notch is attached to the handle adjacent to the head.

13. The hammer as set forth in claim 1 wherein the at least one notch is integrally formed as part of the head.

14. A hammer, comprising: a head with a striking face for driving nails in a first plane; at least one notch spaced apart from the striking face and orientated for pulling a nail in a second plane that is orthogonal to the first plane; a handle extending from the head to a distal end; the handle having a first surface with a contoured profile and an opposing second surface that is substantially planar; and the contoured profile of the first surface including a pair of outer ridges and a center ridge that is positioned between the outer ridges, the outer ridges and the center ridge extending along a majority of a length of the handle.

15. The hammer as set forth in claim 14, wherein the handle includes a first portion adjacent the head and a second portion adjacent the distal end, and wherein the handle has a reduced width along a full length of the second portion than at any point in the first portion.

16. The hammer as set forth in claim 15 wherein the outer ridges have constant thicknesses along a length of the handle and the center ridge has a varying thickness along the length of the handle.

17. The hammer as set forth in claim 16, wherein the center ridge has a first thickness adjacent the head and has a second thickness adjacent the distal end and wherein the second thickness is less than the first thickness.

18. The hammer as set forth in claim 14, wherein the head further includes a pair of claws extending from the head to distal ends, the distal ends of the claws lying in a common plane with a lower surface of the front portion of the head; and wherein the planar second surface of the handle includes a plurality of angle indicia with lines that point directly towards the distal ends of the claws so that the hammer can be rotated about a pivot point established by the distal ends of the claws to a desired angle so that a line at that angle can be established using the handle as a guide.

19. A hammer, comprising: a head with a striking face for driving nails and a pair of claws for pulling nails; at least one notch spaced between the striking face and the claws for pulling nails in a second plane that is orthogonal to the first plane; a handle extending from the head to a distal end; the handle having a first surface with a contoured profile and an opposing second surface that is substantially planar; and the contoured profile of the first surface including a pair of outer ridges and a center ridge that is positioned between the outer ridges, the outer ridges and the center ridge extending along substantially an entire length of the handle.

20. The hammer as set forth in claim 19, wherein the handle has a first width adjacent the head and a second width that is less than the first width adjacent the distal end.
